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UNIT 3: CREATIVE INVENTIONS & LIFE ISSUES

# **Chapter 20: Women Choose to Opt Out**

The Definitive Exam Revision Booklet

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Subject: Tunisian Baccalaureate English Curriculum (Skills for Life)

Focus: Advanced Reading Comprehension, Contrast & Concession, Dependent Prepositions, Phonetic Word Stress, and Writing Argumentative Essays.

Target Audience: Year 4 Secondary Education Students (Tunisia)

Platform: mathbacai.com - Excellence in Secondary Education

## Part 1: The Exhaustive Course Theory

This chapter, 'Women Choose to Opt Out', addresses one of the most critical societal and economic themes in the Skills for Life textbook: the complex dilemma professional women face between pursuing executive positions and stepping out of the workforce (opting out) to focus on family duties. This theme regularly appears in Tunisian Baccalaureate exams as a subject for reading comprehension, vocabulary derivation, and argumentative writing.

### 1. Core Thematic Lexicon Portfolio

| Key Term & Pronunciation                             | French Translation        | Academic Context & Usage                                                                              |
|------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>to opt out (v)</b><br>/ɒpt aʊt/                   | se retirer / renoncer     | Deciding to leave a high-stress career. e.g., Many high-flyers opt out to raise their kids.           |
| <b>high-flyer (n)</b><br>/ˌhaɪˈflaɪ.ər/              | cadre dynamique ambitieux | An extremely ambitious and successful person. e.g., Sarah was a corporate high-flyer.                 |
| <b>glass ceiling (n)</b><br>/ɡlɑːs ˈsiː.lɪŋ/         | plafond de verre          | An invisible barrier preventing women from reaching top roles. e.g., She shattered the glass ceiling. |
| <b>career break (n)</b><br>/kəˈrɪər breɪk/           | pause professionnelle     | A temporary period away from employment. e.g., Taking a career break for parental care.               |
| <b>domestic chores (n)</b><br>/dəˈmes.tɪk tʃɔːz/     | tâches ménagères          | Routine household duties. e.g., Balancing corporate work with domestic chores.                        |
| <b>child-rearing (n)</b><br>/ˈtʃaɪld.rɪə.rɪŋ/        | éducation des enfants     | The process of raising children. e.g., Traditional roles often place child-rearing on mothers.        |
| <b>breadwinner (n)</b><br>/ˈbred.wɪn.ər/             | soutien de famille        | The primary wage earner in a household. e.g., He became the sole breadwinner of the family.           |
| <b>to balance (v)</b><br>/ˈbæl.əns/                  | concilier / équilibrer    | To give equal importance to different activities. e.g., Working mothers balance jobs and home.        |
| <b>to sacrifice (v)</b><br>/ˈsæk.rɪ.faɪs/            | sacrifier                 | Giving up a career for other valuable aspects. e.g., She sacrificed her status for peace of mind.     |
| <b>corporate ladder (n)</b><br>/ˈkɔː.pər.ət ˈlæd.ər/ | échelons de l'entreprise  | The hierarchical path to advancement. e.g., Climbing the corporate ladder requires huge sacrifices.   |

### 2. Grammar Mastery: Concession & Contrast Linkers

In the Baccalaureate exam, you will frequently be asked to rephrase sentences or fill in blanks using concession and contrast linkers. Understanding the distinct syntax of each is highly critical.

Category A: Although / Even though / Though (Suivis d'une proposition complète S+V)

- Rule: [Linker] + Subject + Verb + Object, Main Clause
- Example: Although she loved her corporate job, she decided to opt out. (Correct)
- Exam Pitfall: Never use 'but' in the same sentence as although. (e.g., Although she was tired, but she worked → INCORRECT).

Category B: Despite / In spite of (Suivis d'un Groupe Nominal ou d'un Gérondif en V-ing)

- Rule: [Linker] + Noun Phrase / V-ing, Main Clause

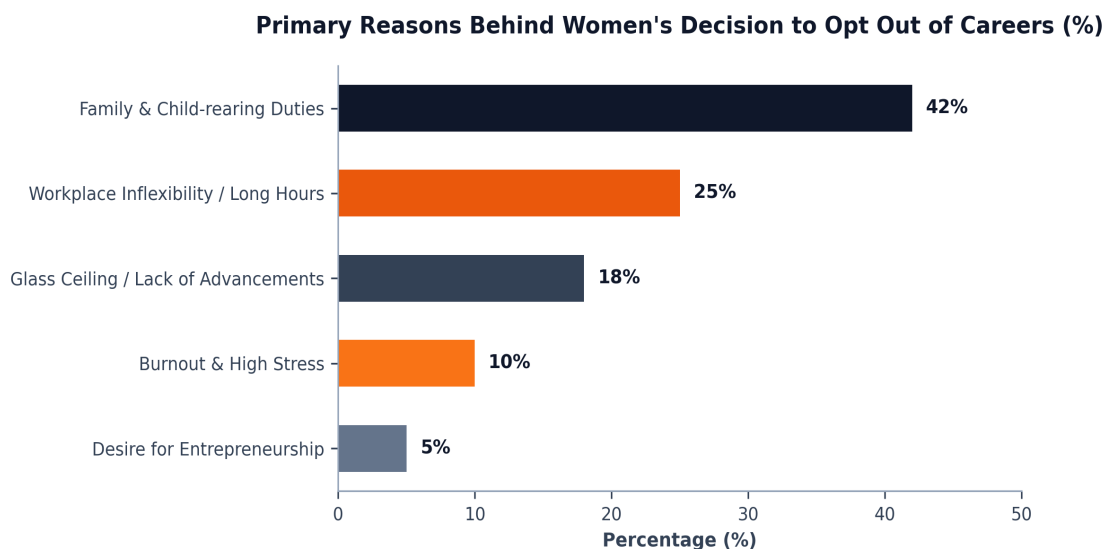
- Example 1 (Noun Phrase): Despite her high salary, she stayed at home.
- Example 2 (Gerund): In spite of having a master's degree, she chose to raise her child full-time.
- Formula Tip: You can use 'the fact that' to bypass the noun rule. e.g., Despite the fact that she was a high-flyer, she resigned.

Category C: Whereas / While (Contraste direct entre deux sujets)

- Rule: Clause 1 + whereas/while + Clause 2 (used to contrast two completely different situations or entities).
- Example: Men are expected to be the main breadwinners, whereas women are often pressured to handle domestic chores.

### 3. Analytical Data Visualization: Women's Career Opt-Out Factors

The following diagram summarizes the statistical drivers behind career opt-out choices among female professionals, reflecting the central themes of the text on page 136 of the manual. Use these percentages to enrich your argumentative essays.



### 4. Phonetics Module: Stress Shifts & Suffix Pronunciation

In the oral/phonetics section of the exam, focus on stress shifts in derivations and the pronunciation of plurals and third-person singular s-endings:

- Word Stress Shifts in Core Vocabulary:

- CA-reer /kə'riər/ : Stress falls on the second syllable.
- OP-option /'ɒp.ʃən/ → to OPT /ɒpt/ : Stressed on the base syllable.
- PRO-fessional /prə'feʃ.ən.əl/ : Stress falls on the second syllable (-fess).
- OP-portunity /,ɒp.ə'tjuː.nə.ti/ : Primary stress is on the third syllable (-tu-).

- Pronunciation of Final '-s' (Exam Alert!):

- /s/ (after voiceless sounds: p, t, k, f, θ): breaks, drops, parents
- /z/ (after voiced sounds: b, d, g, v, ð, l, m, n, r, vowels): careers, duties, mothers, breadwinners
- /ɪz/ (after sibilants: s, z, ʃ, tʃ, dʒ): chooses, balances, managers, houses

### 5. Writing Methodology & Model Essay

**Exam Writing Prompt: 'Should highly educated women opt out of their careers to become full-time mothers, or should they strive to balance both worlds? Write a structured, 12-line argumentative paragraph.'**

**Model Essay (Highly Rated):**

Although pursuing a successful career brings financial autonomy and personal fulfillment, many educated women choose to opt out of the corporate race in order to focus on child-rearing. Despite their impressive diplomas, these high-flyers often face a rigid working culture that makes balancing domestic duties and professional schedules nearly impossible. In fact, while men easily climb the corporate ladder, women are frequently held back by the invisible glass ceiling and heavy household expectations. Consequently, many mothers sacrifice their social status so as to provide direct, dedicated education to their children. However, rather than giving up entirely, modern societies must offer flexible hours so that talented women do not have to make such a heartbreaking compromise between family life and professional stardom.

## Part 2: The Active Recall Repository

This double-column section is designed for active self-evaluation. To practice effectively, fold the page or cover the right-hand column (Model Answer) and attempt to answer the left-hand column (Exam Question).

| Exam Question                                                                                 | Model Answer & Key Concepts                                                                                                                      |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Q1: What does 'to opt out' mean in the context of Chapter 20?</b>                          | It means to voluntarily withdraw from a career or the corporate ladder, usually to prioritize family duties or personal life.                    |
| <b>Q2: Who are the 'high-flyers' mentioned in the text?</b>                                   | They are highly ambitious, well-educated, and successful female professionals who climb the corporate ladder very rapidly.                       |
| <b>Q3: What is the 'glass ceiling'?</b>                                                       | It is an unofficial, invisible barrier in corporate hierarchies that prevents women or minorities from reaching executive-level positions.       |
| <b>Q4: Why do many professional women decide to take a career break?</b>                      | Mainly to dedicate their time to child-rearing and manage domestic duties which are difficult to combine with long corporate hours.              |
| <b>Q5: What are 'domestic duties'?</b>                                                        | These are routine household tasks, such as cleaning, cooking, laundry, and daily childcare, traditionally assigned to women.                     |
| <b>Q6: Explain the term 'breadwinner'.</b>                                                    | A breadwinner is the primary wage earner whose income supports the family's basic needs and living expenses.                                     |
| <b>Q7: What is the main conflict faced by corporate mothers?</b>                              | The conflict between pursuing career ambition (corporate success) and fulfilling traditional family and child-rearing expectations.              |
| <b>Q8: According to the text, is opting out always a permanent choice?</b>                    | No, some women take a temporary career break and intend to return once their children reach school age, though many find it hard to reintegrate. |
| <b>Q9: What does 'rigid workplace structure' refer to?</b>                                    | It refers to traditional office models requiring strict 9-to-5 presence, long hours, and minimal flexibility for parental obligations.           |
| <b>Q10: Why do some authors call opting out a 'sacrifice'?</b>                                | Because women give up financial independence, professional identity, and status in exchange for family well-being and stability.                 |
| <b>Q11: What is the noun form of the verb 'to choose'?</b>                                    | The noun form is 'choice' (plural: choices).                                                                                                     |
| <b>Q12: Give the noun form of the verb 'to opt' as used in the chapter title.</b>             | The noun form is 'option' (plural: options).                                                                                                     |
| <b>Q13: What is the noun derived from the verb 'to sacrifice'?</b>                            | The noun form remains identical: 'sacrifice' (plural: sacrifices).                                                                               |
| <b>Q14: Derive the adjective form from the noun 'priority'.</b>                               | The adjective form is 'prioritised' or 'priority' (though 'prioritised list' is common, 'primary' or 'key' is often preferred).                  |
| <b>Q15: Provide the opposite of the noun 'breadwinner' in a traditional family structure.</b> | The opposite is 'homemaker' or 'housewife' (one who manages domestic chores rather than earning wages).                                          |

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| <b>Q16: Find a synonym for 'ambitious and successful person' from the text.</b>                          | The synonym is 'high-flyer'.                                                                                                       |
| <b>Q17: What is the noun form of the verb 'to prioritize'?</b>                                           | The noun form is 'prioritization' or 'priority'.                                                                                   |
| <b>Q18: What is the adjective form of the noun 'privilege'?</b>                                          | The adjective form is 'privileged'.                                                                                                |
| <b>Q19: Fill in the blank: 'Her decision to resign was a clear ___ of her priorities.' (demonstrate)</b> | The correct noun is 'demonstration'.                                                                                               |
| <b>Q20: Give the adjective form of the noun 'tradition'.</b>                                             | The adjective form is 'traditional'.                                                                                               |
| <b>Q21: Rephrase: 'Although she had a high salary, she opted out.' (Use: Despite)</b>                    | Despite her high salary, she opted out. (OR: Despite having a high salary...)                                                      |
| <b>Q22: Rephrase: 'Despite being a high-flyer, she resigned.' (Use: Even though)</b>                     | Even though she was a high-flyer, she resigned.                                                                                    |
| <b>Q23: Is this correct: 'Although she was tired, but she finished her chores.'?</b>                     | No. You must never use 'although' and 'but' in the same sentence. Remove 'but': 'Although she was tired, she finished her chores.' |
| <b>Q24: Rephrase using 'unless': 'If she does not get flexible hours, she will opt out.'</b>             | Unless she gets flexible hours, she will opt out.                                                                                  |
| <b>Q25: Combine: 'Sarah loves corporate law. Her sister prefers staying at home.' (Use: whereas)</b>     | Sarah loves corporate law, whereas her sister prefers staying at home.                                                             |
| <b>Q26: Rephrase: 'She took a break so that she could raise her children.' (Use: in order to)</b>        | She took a break in order to raise her children.                                                                                   |
| <b>Q27: Complete: 'In spite of her ___ (determine), she could not break the glass ceiling.'</b>          | In spite of her determination (noun required after 'in spite of her').                                                             |
| <b>Q28: Correct the error: 'Despite she worked hard, she was not promoted.'</b>                          | Correction: 'Despite working hard...' or 'Despite the fact that she worked hard...'                                                |
| <b>Q29: Rephrase: 'She did not resign because she wanted to save her family.' (Use: so as not to)</b>    | She did not resign so as not to abandon her career. / She balanced her work so as not to sacrifice her family.                     |

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| <b>Q30: Complete with 'who' or 'which': 'The corporate rules, ___ are very rigid, push mothers out.'</b> | The correct relative pronoun is 'which' (used for non-restrictive relative clauses referring to things).                                         |
| <b>Q31: Classify the final -s in 'breaks' into /s/, /z/, or /ɪz/.</b>                                    | It is pronounced as /s/ because it follows the voiceless sound /k/.                                                                              |
| <b>Q32: Classify the final -s in 'duties' into /s/, /z/, or /ɪz/.</b>                                    | It is pronounced as /z/ because it follows a vowel sound.                                                                                        |
| <b>Q33: Where is the primary stress in 'career' /kəˈrɪər/?</b>                                           | The stress falls on the second syllable (ca-REER).                                                                                               |
| <b>Q34: Where is the primary stress in 'opportunity' /ˌɒp.əˈtjuː.nə.ti/?</b>                             | The primary stress is on the third syllable (-tu-).                                                                                              |
| <b>Q35: Is the 'h' in 'high-flyer' silent or pronounced?</b>                                             | It is fully pronounced /haɪˈflaɪ.ər/.                                                                                                            |
| <b>Q36: Which syllable is stressed in 'professional' /prəˈfeʃ.ən.əl/?</b>                                | The second syllable (-fess-).                                                                                                                    |
| <b>Q37: Classify the -s in 'chooses' into /s/, /z/, or /ɪz/.</b>                                         | It is pronounced as /ɪz/ because the base verb ends in a sibilant sound /z/.                                                                     |
| <b>Q38: What writing structure is best to write a balanced paragraph?</b>                                | An argumentative structure: introduce the topic, present reasons for opting out, contrast with the opposing view, and conclude with a synthesis. |
| <b>Q39: Identify the silent letter in 'climb' /klaɪm/.</b>                                               | The silent letter is 'b'.                                                                                                                        |
| <b>Q40: Correct the spelling: 'Many high-fliers face glass cielings.'</b>                                | Correction: 'Many high-flyers face glass ceilings' (i before e rule violation).                                                                  |

## Part 3: Exam Evaluation Quiz

Test your knowledge under real exam conditions. This section contains 5 Multiple Choice Questions (MCQ) and 5 True or False questions where you must justify your choice using textbook theory or grammar rules.

### Section A: Multiple Choice Questions (MCQs)

1. Professional women who climb corporate ladders very rapidly are called:  
a) Homemakers  
b) High-flyers  
c) Breadwinners
2. Identify the syntactically correct sentence:  
a) Although she had a master's degree, but she chose to stay at home.  
b) Despite she had a master's degree, she chose to stay at home.  
c) In spite of having a master's degree, she chose to stay at home.
3. The invisible barrier that limits women's career advancement is called:  
a) The steel roof  
b) The glass ceiling  
c) The open window
4. Which of the following words has the stress on the second syllable?  
a) Priority  
b) Opportunity  
c) Option
5. In the word 'climb', the silent letter is:  
a) c  
b) l  
c) b

### Section B: True or False with Justification

6. 'In spite of' must always be followed by a complete clause (Subject + Verb).
7. The word 'duties' has its final -s pronounced as /s/.
8. Opting out is always a forced decision and never a voluntary choice.
9. The sentence 'Despite her successful career, she took a break.' is grammatically correct.
10. In a traditional family, the mother is referred to as the primary breadwinner.

## Pedagogical Correction & Grading Key

### Section A: MCQs Answers & Explanations

1. b) High-flyers → High-flyer refers to highly successful and ambitious professionals.
2. c) In spite of having... → 'In spite of' takes a gerund (V-ing) or noun. Option (a) has a double-connector error ('although... but'). Option (b) incorrectly uses 'despite' followed by a clause.
3. b) The glass ceiling → This is the literal textbook terminology for this invisible barrier.
4. a) Priority → Priority is stressed on the second syllable (pri-OR-i-ty). 'Opportunity' is stressed on the third, and 'Option' on the first.
5. c) b → The 'b' is completely silent at the end of 'climb' /'klaɪm/.

### Section B: True/False Answers & Justifications

6. False: 'In spite of' (like 'despite') is a prepositional linker and must be followed by a noun phrase or a gerund (V-ing), not a complete clause.
7. False: The final -s in 'duties' is pronounced /z/ because the preceding sound is a vowel (voiced sound).
8. False: The text highlights that many professional women 'choose' to opt out voluntarily to focus on their family values and children's welfare.
9. True: 'Despite' is correctly followed by the noun phrase 'her successful career'.
10. False: In traditional families, the father is typically the primary breadwinner, whereas the mother is the homemaker.

## Summary Memos & Exam Cheat-Sheets

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
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| <p><b>Memo 1.1: Concession &amp; Contrast Linkers Matrix</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Subordinating (S+V required): Although / Even though / Though / While / Whereas</li> <li>- Example: Although she was a high-flyer, she resigned.</li> <li>• Prepositional (Noun / V-ing required): Despite / In spite of</li> <li>- Example: Despite her determination, she resigned.</li> <li>• Adverbial (Sentence starting): However / Nevertheless / Yet</li> <li>- Example: She worked hard. However, she was passed over.</li> </ul> | <p><b>Memo 1.2: Phonetics &amp; Word Endings Summary</b></p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Final '-s' Rules:               <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- /s/ after voiceless sounds: caps, breaks, checks</li> <li>- /z/ after voiced sounds/vowels: careers, duties, systems</li> <li>- /ɪz/ after sibilant sounds: chooses, passes, rises</li> </ul> </li> <li>• Silent Letters to Memorize:               <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>- 'b' in: climb, doubt, debt</li> <li>- 'k' in: knowledge, knee, knife</li> </ul> </li> </ul> |
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